Shikarpur, where they were supposed to liaise with the Bombay army and Shah Shuja's Contingent. The Sikhs meanwhile headed north towards Lahore.

The Army of the Indus now consisted of around a thousand Europeans and 14,000 East India Company sepoys – excluding the 6,000 irregulars hired by Shuja – accompanied by no fewer than 38,000 Indian camp followers. The baggage for these men was to be carried to war on over 30,000 camels, which had been collected for the purpose from as far away as Bikaner, Jaisalmer and the Company's camel stud at Hisar in Haryana.

No one was planning to travel light. One brigadier claimed that he needed fifty camels to carry his kit, while General Cotton took 260 for his. Three hundred camels were earmarked to carry the military wine cellar. Even junior officers travelled with as many as forty servants – ranging from cooks and sweepers to bearers and water carriers.[18] According to Major-General Nott, who had had to work his way up throughout his career without the benefit of connections, patronage or money and who looked with a jaundiced eye on the rich young officers of the Queen's Regiments, it was already clear that the army was not enforcing proper military austerity. Many of the junior officers were treating the war as if it were as light-hearted as a hunting trip – indeed one regiment had actually brought its own foxhounds along with it to the front. 'Many young officers would as soon have thought of leaving behind their swords and double-barrelled pistols as march without their dressing cases, their perfumes, Windsor soap and eau de Cologne,' he wrote. 'One regiment has two camels carrying the best Manila cigars, while other camels carry jams, pickles, cheroots, potted fish, hermetically sealed meats, plate, glass, crockery, wax-candles, table linen, &c.'[19]

It did not bode well for the effectiveness of the fighting force. Nor did the lack of communication between the different wings of the Army of the Indus. By now Alexander Burnes was supposed to have completed the negotiations with the Amirs of Sindh and to have received the necessary permissions for the army to pass up the river and through their lands. But the attack on Karachi coupled with the looting of Larkana instead nearly sparked a second war between the British and the Sindhis even before the planned war against Dost Mohammad had got under way. The Sindhis, quite understandably, did not want a British army tramping across their territory, so dragged their feet over permissions and refused to find camels